NTER-STRIKE

INDIA

- **Use former CM Hemant Soren's arrest by the ED in alleged land scam case to portray BJP as anti-tribal**
- **Tap into the legacy of JMM patriarch Shibu Soren and the sympathy for and popularity of Hemant's wife Kalpana**
- **Project JMM-Congress-RJD as a cohesive coalition, highlighting their pro-poor policies**
- **Unify anti-BJP votes by highlighting alleged injustices, such as "denial of rights of people of Jharkhand"**

prominent Adivasi author and social activist.

While the JMM hopes to cash in on the public resentment over Soren's arrest, Jharkhand BJP president Babulal Marandi asserts that the former CM cannot be absolved of corruption allegations. "He is not a victim but a perpetrator, and we are making this known to everyone." State BJP leaders, however, admit to being wary of a potential tribal backlash, on the lines of the 2019 assembly election debacle. Months after winning 12 of the 14 Lok Sabha seats in Jharkhand in 2019, the BJP and its allies lost the assembly polls to the Congress-JMM-RJD, purportedly because of its poor show in the 28 seats reserved for STs, of which the BJP won only two. The saffron loss in the assembly polls was ascribed to the controversial attempt by Raghubar Das, a BJP leader and the state's only non-tribal CM—who held the post from 2014-19—to amend two land laws—the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act, 1908, and the Santhal Pargana Tenancy Act, 1949.

The BJP has since appointed Marandi as the new state party chief in July 2023. Marandi, a Santhal tribal like Soren, had served as the first chief minister of Jharkhand. "We have conveyed the message that there cannot be any emotional outpouring for Soren and his associates," Marandi told INDIA TODAY. The BJP is also using its appointment of Droupadi Murmu, a former Jharkhand governor, as India's first tribal president in 2022 to establish its "pro-tribal stance".

The party is also trying to beat possible anti-incumbency in five seats by fielding new faces. It has dropped sitting Dumka MP Sunil Soren in favour of Hemant's sister-in-law Sita. Similarly, Jayant Sinha, son of former BJP leader Yashwant Sinha, has been replaced by Manish Jaiswal in Hazaribag and Sunil Singh has been denied a ticket in Chatra in favour of Kalicharan Singh. Additionally, three-term MP Pashupati Nath Singh has been dropped in Dhanbad, with the BJP fielding legislator Dhullu Mahto. And three-time Lohardaga MP Sudarshan Bhagat has been dropped, with the party's Rajya Sabha MP Sameer Oraon contesting from the seat. Meanwhile, the lone Congress MP from Jharkhand, Geeta Koda, who switched over to the BJP ahead of the election, is contesting from Singhbhum.

The 2024 general election brings "a clash of ideologies, with a multitude of influences stirring within the collective consciousness of the electorate," says Ranchi-based political analyst Surjeet Singh. It presents a puzzle that is unlike the relative predictability of the 2019 Lok Sabha election, he adds. We will have to wait till June 4 to find out the solution to that puzzle. ■



THE BETTER HALF Kalpana Soren campaigns in Gandey on May 3, ahead of the May 20 by-poll

assembly by-poll scheduled for May 20, has been seen at public events with INDIA bloc leaders, including Congress MP Rahul Gandhi earlier this month.

Party sources told INDIA TODAY that in the months following Soren's arrest, she has managed to instil confidence in the JMM cadre and keep the party ranks united, at the same time using the public sympathy for Soren to the party's advantage, projecting the ED action against her husband as an example of the Centre's oppressive tactics against Opposition leaders.

In doing so, Kalpana, an engineering graduate who also holds an MBA degree and is an eloquent speaker to boot, has exhibited a political acumen of her own. ■